



empirical — in other words, ‘reduce total load without lowering intensity’. In the real world, there are many more ways to ease load while maintaining periodic high-intensity stimuli. For example, replacing a Zone 2 endurance run with a very easy Zone 1 run.

Through this process, we keep training volume relatively high but reduce training load, while still maintaining one high-intensity session. In that session, we can reduce the magnitude of the stimulus while keeping the same type by doing fewer intervals or using longer recoveries.

This is ideal for athletes with a lot of available time who habitually struggle mentally if they have to reduce training hours too much. Such athletes can become more prone to weight gain, losing focus, reduced adaptation, or overthinking in the lead-up to competitions.

To know how much tapering you need, copying previous recipes is useless. Trying to extract patterns

from CTL (Chronic Training Load), ATL (Acute Training Load), and TSB (Training Stress Balance) will not help either.

In fact, excessive trust in these metrics is largely responsible for athletes believing they must reduce training hours in the week before competition, since the parent metric, TSS (Training Stress Score), is highly dependent on total volume in its calculation.

Here are a few pointers before employing tapering in training:

1. Understand why it is done and the process to be followed.

2. Have internal load metrics that allow you to assess your level of systemic fatigue and how your performance has evolved in the previous weeks. Based on this, detect how far you have gone and how much you need to return to your optimal levels of freshness and performance. This is totally bespoke to each individual athlete.

3. Tweak all of this to your sport, skill, context, and other variable

Strategic regeneration: The target of tapering is to train to a lesser extent than you are able to recover from, allowing the body to regenerate after previous fatigue, while at the same time trying to maintain the adaptations achieved earlier. GETTY IMAGES

needs. Some athletes prefer to keep training for a lot of hours, while others prefer to train less in order to have time to organise other aspects of their lives and travel to competitions feeling calm and composed. **Trying to copy what professionals do through social media or hearsay sports scientists, without understanding oneself and without professional guidance, can be an appetite for destruction.**

Every player will have his or her own way to taper in line with loads of variables depending on the competition timetable — from a single point of focus to multiple events. Planning is the catalyst for progressive results.